

financial woes for the doctor, and the attorney realized that a pattern was developing. I suggested that the doctor and his wife come in for counsel.

It turned out that this doctor had used some of his employee's withholding tax funds to invest in a great "deal" being touted by another Christian. He forgot about using the tax money and didn't pay his quarterly withholding. However, the IRS didn't forget, and when several notices failed to get a response, they attached his assets.

A little negotiating got the attachments lifted and the doctor started paying monthly to clear the back taxes. He did well for about three months. Then a friend offered him a great buy on a sailboat (to make a quick profit). Lacking the necessary funds, he again dipped into his tax funds. He intended to pay the money back out of his quick profits. This idea of quick profit is known as "the greater sucker theory." In other words, if you're sucker enough to buy it, there must be a greater sucker than you around who will pay a higher price.

Well, the boat didn't sell and he missed another tax payment. This time the IRS attached everything, even his checking accounts. He couldn't even write a check for groceries. He was physically ill when he called to ask for help. On the way to my office, he told his wife, "Whatever he tells me to do, I'm going to do it, God, I swear."

Incidentally, this might be a good time to mention Solomon's words in Ecclesiastes 5:4: "When you make a vow to God, do not be late in paying it, for He takes no delight in fools. Pay what you vow!" So be careful about urgent vows or you might get stuck with them.

I didn't know about the doctor's vow, but I did have a plan in mind that his attorney and I had discussed. He walked in, ghost-white, and quite obviously under great stress. The IRS agent had mentioned "fraud" and "prosecution," which are terms that strike fear in the hearts of virtually every taxpayer.

I shared a story with him that I believed would fit his situation perfectly. I asked, "Would you agree that your problem is not a lack of money?"